



Lost_in_translation

【经济学人播客 Drum Tower 迷失在翻译中：语言如何使美中关系更加复杂】

Summary: The Economist explores how language barriers and translation challenges impact diplomatic relations, particularly between China and the US, highlighting real-world consequences of misinterpretations.

摘要：《经济学人》探讨了语言障碍和翻译挑战如何影响外交关系，尤其是中美之间，强调了误译的现实后果。



 Estimated Reading Time: 62 min

 四级生词  六级生词  雅思生词  托福生词  专八生词  SAT生词  考研生词 
GRE生词  高考生词  其它生词生词

Table of Contents

- 00:00:04 The Economist.
- 00:00:44 To Chinese ears, though, this can sound a bit stronger, like
- 00:01:09 I and Jihau Chen, the economist's China researcher and drumm
- 00:01:32 This is Stromb Tower, from the Economist.
- 00:02:01 I'm actually quite curious when you decided to pick up Chine
- 00:02:27 So it was a COVID hobby.
- 00:02:54 Well, I can certainly attest that Chinese is a very difficul
- 00:03:15 Yeah, I can see that.
- 00:03:39 But actually, how you translate that, the leading power or A
- 00:04:03 Yes, we mentioned a bit of this in the, is China becoming ca
- 00:04:26 So we're going to go a bit back to front here.
- 00:04:50 Okay, gotcha.
- 00:05:16 Some people often think about it as telling the good China s
- 00:05:37 Is this a community of common destiny for mankind?
- 00:06:03 As I understand it, common destiny went down very poorly wit
- 00:06:23 And so when China goes around to other countries, often aski
- 00:06:42 That's kind of about like hiding ones, capabilities or geniu
- 00:06:58 It sounds a little like high.
- 00:07:24 Those who play with fire will get burned.
- 00:07:50 It almost loses its emotive content.
- 00:08:12 What is that?
- 00:08:22 Yeah.
- 00:08:34 It's teaching things like to call the world's dependence on
- 00:08:55 It doesn't sound great.
- 00:09:14 You're meant to say things that are quite catchy.
- 00:09:34 Yeah.

- 00:09:56 And so when I was reporting this story, I was lucky enough t
- 00:10:17 Exactly.
- 00:10:40 Did you get a sense from him if Chinese was the hardest for
- 00:10:58 He said probably somebody's told you that Chinese is a very
- 00:11:18 That's exactly right.
- 00:11:38 Oh wow.
- 00:12:01 I mean, even within mainland China there are different diale
- 00:12:21 The Chinese word for deterrence in Taiwan was hutsu to intim
- 00:12:47 She pronounced it wa niah.
- 00:13:11 And that is shudger, which means to intimidate and stop.
- 00:13:40 If just being in the room the way you interpret the word det
- 00:14:04 Yeah, makes sense.
- 00:14:25 So this is, of course, the Shanghai communique in 1979.
- 00:14:49 Was Charles there to witness and sort of help negotiate?
- 00:15:14 So I do not know why that happened, but the only explanation
- 00:15:48 Yeah, so what's funny is that not only does the English and
- 00:16:21 Oh, so they're the same as the Chinese snuck it in.
- 00:16:45 It's not an outlier.
- 00:17:10 I know that sometimes with the translation of the foreign mi
- 00:17:32 But I've also noticed that the English subtitles they put ov
- 00:17:56 Another common problematic translation is of competitor.
- 00:18:21 But a little bit different, right?
- 00:18:45 Then when I pressed and asked, but really, what is the case
- 00:19:19 And that can have very real, real world consequences.
- 00:19:46 Hello, good to be back.
- 00:20:08 I guess we're about to hear it.
- 00:20:30 What does this mean when he sees the packet of cash?
- 00:20:53 That's very good.
- 00:21:18 And my experience is when you're talking Chinese with people
- 00:21:32 I would ask my question in Chinese, Jihou knew what I meant,
- 00:21:49 Maybe it's just they're just taking me at face value.
- 00:22:08 And other times, Chinese is just not very straightforward.
- 00:22:30 And I was saying, Lee Yong, like, use.
- 00:22:51 I'm here to exploit you, yes.
- 00:23:11 Do you agree with that statement?
- 00:23:34 But everyone understands that the stronger party is still th

- 00:23:56 Of course.
- 00:24:16 Over your time reporting on China, do you think there are an
- 00:24:36 So some may remember that there was an American spy plane th
- 00:25:00 And the crew was held as hostages and I was down with lots o
- 00:25:20 That's how they'll do it.
- 00:25:38 And that apology was the core of the problem.
- 00:26:02 So that was the fudge.
- 00:26:23 So at the lower end of this spectrum, we have Bo Yisa, which
- 00:26:46 So in the piece that I wrote back in 2001 without my then br
- 00:27:05 I am very sorry.
- 00:27:34 You know, that they weren't certainly weren't as tough as Ch
- 00:27:55 Had you heard of this, David?
- 00:28:11 That the Chinese side back in 2001, they played around with
- 00:28:36 But I don't hold me to that.
- 00:29:03 Because the China of the day, it was less nationalist than t
- 00:29:22 But I think today's partisan politics and media environment
- 00:29:44 I remember this is back in 2019 when the then Houston Rocket
- 00:30:06 It was like, we're deeply disappointed in what this manager
- 00:30:25 Right.
- 00:30:54 And they said about doing machine translations of ultra-nati
- 00:31:15 That the crime was to reveal what was actually being said in
- 00:31:36 And then meanwhile, there's red and white banners on the str
- 00:31:53 How many times a phrase was mentioned in an annual governmen
- 00:32:18 And actually that's a return to the old school.
- 00:32:32 I do.
- 00:32:53 It's kind of come full circle.
- 00:33:16 That must have an impact on China's delivery as well.
- 00:33:47 But of course, for the Chinese side, Xi Jinping does not go
- 00:34:08 That's why they're stuck.
- 00:34:33 Yeah, I think that what we've seen is that in the past, diff
- 00:34:56 I think that that's a noble sentiment.
- 00:35:15 I mean, not to sound like the kind of the old foreign corres
- 00:35:34 It's a power play.
- 00:35:56 Because it was seen as this kind of power thing that as long
- 00:36:15 I basically agree.
- 00:36:34 Well, this conversation has been Genio Yis.

- 00:37:00 Please keep sending us more at [drum at economist.com](http://drum.economist.com).
 - 00:37:25 It's really worth listening to.
-

00:00:04

 The Economist.

《经济学人》

 Good relationships depend on good communication, but when neither party speaks the same language, there's plenty of opportunity for things to get lost in translation.

良好的关系依赖于良好的沟通，但当双方语言不通时，误解的可能性就会大大增加。

 Earlier this year, when Wang Yi and Marco Rubio, China and America's top diplomats spoke on the phone, Mr. Wang used an idiomatic phrase, 好自为之, an ambiguous expression that can be translated as make the right choice.

今年早些时候，中国和美国的外交高层王毅和马可·卢比奥通电话时，王毅使用了一个成语“好自为之”，这个模糊的表达可以翻译为“做出正确选择”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:00:44

 To Chinese ears, though, this can sound a bit stronger, like a boss putting a junior in his place.

但在中文语境中，这句话听起来可能更严厉，像是上级对下级的训诫。

 Language and how it's interpreted matters.

语言及其解读方式至关重要。

 It has the power to diffuse or to inflame.

它既能缓和紧张，也能激化矛盾。

▶ And as the relationship between China and America enters a new, less predictable phase, linguistic slide of hand has the potential to become more consequential.

随着中美关系进入一个更加不可预测的新阶段，语言上的微妙差异可能会带来更严重的后果。

[Back to Top](#)

00:01:09

▶ I and Jihau Chen, the economist's China researcher and drummed Harcducer.

我和《经济学人》的中国研究员陈继浩以及鼓手哈克杜瑟。

▶ This week, I'm joined by Corbin Duncan, our global correspondent and David Renny, our geopolitics editor.

本周，我们的全球记者科尔宾·邓肯和地缘政治编辑大卫·伦尼也加入了讨论。

▶ And we're asking, why is Chinese such a hard language to translate?

我们探讨的问题是：为什么中文如此难以翻译？

▶ And what are the real world consequences when the message gets lost in translation?

以及信息在翻译中丢失时，现实世界会面临哪些后果？

[Back to Top](#)

00:01:32

▶ This is Stromb Tower, from the Economist.

这里是《经济学人》的“鼓楼”栏目。

▶ Hey Corbin, welcome to Dromb Tower.

嘿，科尔宾，欢迎来到“鼓楼”。

▶ Hey Jihau, thanks for having me on.

嘿，继浩，谢谢邀请我。

🎧 On a rate of 1-10, how nervous are you about doing an episode on Chinese?

以1到10分为标准，你对做一期关于中文的节目有多紧张？

🎧 Very nervous.

非常紧张。

🎧 I'm terrified that my Chinese friends are going to make fun of me for my pronunciation.

我害怕我的中国朋友会因为我的发音而嘲笑我。

🎧 So I'm in the deep end here.

所以我这次是豁出去了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:02:01

🎧 I'm actually quite curious when you decided to pick up Chinese because you didn't learn Chinese as a major and unique, right?

我其实很好奇你是什么时候决定学习中文的，因为你并不是以中文为专业或独特方向，对吧？

🎧 No, that's right.

是的，没错。

🎧 I learned Chinese in 2022 when I was living in Beijing.

我是在2022年住在北京时学习中文的。

🎧 And if you remember at that time, there were a lot of COVID lockdowns.

如果你还记得，那时候有很多疫情封锁措施。

🎧 And so I had a lot of time to myself in my dorm room and I kind of decided I was going to use that time for when I was free to go out and travel around China to learn the language and try to nail it down.

所以我有很多时间待在宿舍里，我决定利用这些时间，等到可以自由出行时，去中国各地旅行并学习语言，努力掌握它。

[Back to Top](#)

00:02:27

▶ So it was a COVID hobby.

所以这是疫情期间的一个爱好。

▶ A coping mechanism perhaps.

或许是一种应对机制。

▶ So today we're going to begin by talking about why Chinese is a particularly tricky language to translate into English.

今天我们将首先讨论为什么中文尤其难以翻译成英文。

▶ We will meet a veteran interpreter and then David will join us to discuss some of the real world consequences of mis-translation.

我们将采访一位资深翻译，然后大卫会加入我们，讨论误译的一些现实后果。

▶ But just to start with Corbin, I'm curious, you know, in your opinion, what makes Chinese so tricky to translate?

但首先，科尔宾，我很好奇，你认为是什么让中文如此难以翻译？

[Back to Top](#)

00:02:54

▶ Well, I can certainly attest that Chinese is a very difficult language for non-native speakers to learn and to use every day.

我可以肯定地说，中文对非母语者来说是一门非常难学且日常使用困难的语言。

▶ But when it comes to how governments communicate, there are generally three big challenges.

但在政府间的沟通中，通常有三个主要挑战。

▶ So one is the language itself.

首先是语言本身。

▶ In Chinese words often carry a pretty clear, positive or negative association.

中文词汇通常带有明确的褒义或贬义。

[Back to Top](#)

00:03:15

▶ Yeah, I can see that.

是的，我能理解。

▶ So like, when you think about English, we have lots of jargon, lots of words which carry no positive or negative connotation.

比如在英语中，我们有很多术语和中性词，没有明显的褒贬含义。

▶ Chinese doesn't need a neutral or neutral.

中文则缺乏这种中性表达。

▶ Exactly.

没错。

▶ Mandarin also has fewer subordinate clauses and lacks articles like A and or D.

普通话的从句较少，也没有冠词如“a”或“the”。

▶ So ***, promised that his country would become the leading power back in a party meeting in 2017.

比如***在2017年的一次党代会上承诺，中国将成为“领先大国”。

00:03:39

▶ But actually, how you translate that, the leading power or A leading power is really tricky and the difference is quite important.

但如何翻译“领先大国”或“一个领先大国”非常棘手，且差异很重要。

▶ And finally, there is also the question of intention.

最后还有意图的问题。

▶ So the party in government units that are charged with crafting Chinese message for foreign audiences often leverage ambiguity in the language to send one message at home and another abroad.

负责为外国受众设计中文信息的党政机构常常利用语言的模糊性，对内对外传递不同的信息。

00:04:03

▶ Yes, we mentioned a bit of this in the, is China becoming call episode?

是的，我们在“中国是否变得强硬”一集中提到过这一点。

▶ The difference between nation and why shun did come up as well?

“民族”和“国族”的区别也出现了？

▶ Yes, so that's the difference between domestic propaganda and foreign propaganda, right?

是的，这就是对内宣传和对外宣传的区别。

▶ And so often they're sending quite different messages.

因此他们常常传递截然不同的信息。

🎧 And just to get a sense of what a mind field this whole translation business can be, I'm going to throw you a couple of phrases in Chinese.

为了让你感受翻译这件事有多复杂，我会给你几个中文短语。

[Back to Top](#)

00:04:26

🎧 So we're going to go a bit back to front here.

我们会有点倒着来。

🎧 But I want to hear you as a Chinese speaker, understand them.

但我想听听你作为中文使用者如何理解它们。

🎧 And then I'll give you the English translation.

然后我会给出英文翻译。

🎧 I don't know if I should be more nervous about messing the sub-ware of you should be.

我不知道是该更担心搞砸还是你该更担心。

🎧 So I can assure you it's me.

所以我向你保证，是我更担心。

🎧 The goal here is to kind of prove what I was just saying, that what you hear and how it's translated for English audiences may be very different.

目的是证明我刚刚说的，你听到的内容和为英语受众翻译的内容可能大不相同。

[Back to Top](#)

00:04:50

▶ Okay, gotcha.

好的，明白了。

▶ Okay, so the first one, Disha.

第一个，“迪沙”。

▶ Zhang Hao, Zhong Guo, Gu Shui.

“讲好中国故事”。

▶ Zhang Hao, Zhong Guo, is that telling China's stories well?

“讲好中国故事”，这是不是“讲好中国的故事”？

▶ Yeah, so it's often rendered as tell the China's story well.

是的，通常翻译为“讲好中国故事”。

▶ But I was actually speaking with a state media journalist quite recently.

但我最近和一位官方媒体记者聊过。

▶ He kind of rarely remarked that there is some ambiguity here.

他罕见地指出这里有些模糊性。

[Back to Top](#)

00:05:16

▶ Some people often think about it as telling the good China story.

有些人常理解为“讲中国的正面故事”。

▶ Zhang Hao, the Zhong Guo, Gu Shui, I see.

“讲好中国故事”，我明白了。

▶ Exactly.

没错。

▶ So this is one of xxx's popular phrases when it comes to propaganda and encouraging people to go out and explain who China is in the world.

这是***在宣传和鼓励人们向世界解释中国时的常用语。

▶ Okay, so second one.

第二个。

▶ Ren Lei, Ming Yun, Gong Pengti.

“人类命运共同体”。

▶ This one always trips me up.

这个总是让我困惑。

[Back to Top](#)

00:05:37

▶ Is this a community of common destiny for mankind?

这是不是“人类命运共同体”？

▶ So you would have been right a couple of years ago.

几年前你是对的。

▶ Okay.

好的。

▶ That is how state media initially translated it.

这是官方媒体最初的翻译。

▶ But in recent years, they've changed the English, not the Chinese, but the English translation to be a community with a shared future.

但近年来，他们修改了英文翻译（而非中文），改为“共享未来的共同体”。

▶ So the changes from common destiny to shared future.

从“共同命运”改为“共享未来”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:06:03

▶ As I understand it, common destiny went down very poorly with some asian diplomats.

据我所知，“共同命运”让一些亚洲外交官很不满。

▶ They didn't like the idea of a preordained destiny.

他们不喜欢“命中注定”的意味。

▶ Oh, I hadn't thought about that.

哦，我没想到这点。

▶ A shared future is as much broader and open.

“共享未来”更开放和宽泛。

▶ So destiny feels like quite fatalistic about China's preemptive dominance or something.

“命运”听起来像是中国注定主导，有点宿命论。

▶ That's right.

没错。

▶ Oh.

哦。

[Back to Top](#)

00:06:23

▶ And so when China goes around to other countries, often asking them to sort of sign on to these motherhood statements, actually, this made some countries quite unkind.

所以当中国向其他国家推广这些原则性声明时，这实际上让一些国家不太舒服。

▶ I can see that.

我能理解。

▶ Okay.

好的。

▶ Should we go for the third one?

来试试第三个？

▶ This one, I think you would know.

这个你应该知道。

▶ It's a famous Dong Xiaoping policy.

这是邓小平的著名政策。

▶ Tao Guang, Yang Hui.

“韬光养晦”。

▶ Tao Guang, Yang Hui.

“韬光养晦”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:06:42

▶ That's kind of about like hiding ones, capabilities or geniuses and biting ones time.

意思是隐藏实力，等待时机。

▶ That's it.

没错。

▶ Hydro strength by your time.

“隐藏实力，等待时机”。

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ Today in the official translation, it's Keep a Low Profile.

现在官方翻译是“保持低调”。

▶ Oh, why?

哦，为什么？

▶ I guess it sounds nicer.

可能听起来更温和。

▶ Oh.

哦。

[Back to Top](#)

00:06:58

▶ It sounds a little like high.

“隐藏实力”听起来有点.....

▶ Hiding your capabilities feels a bit sort of like you're about to attack or it's a little Machi value.

“隐藏实力”感觉像是准备攻击，有点马基雅维利主义。

▶ Oh, I see.

哦，我明白了。

▶ Okay.

好的。

▶ Right.

对。

▶ Okay.

好的。

▶ To switch things up, I'll give you some of the English translations and let's see how you do putting it back into Chinese.

换一下，我给你一些英文翻译，看看你能不能还原成中文。

▶ So a phrase that's commonly used when it comes to Taiwanese independence is the foreign ministry will give the day marsh of those who play with fire will get burned.

比如在台湾问题上常用的表述是外交部警告“玩火者必自焚”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:07:24

▶ Those who play with fire will get burned.

“玩火者必自焚”。

▶ Is it 玩火者必自焚?

是不是“玩火者必自焚”?

▶ Exactly.

没错。

▶ I can tell how that sounds quite intense because it's a visual language.

我能听出这听起来很严厉，因为这是形象化的语言。

▶ But I don't want people to make the connection between self-immolation and whatnot.

但我不希望人们联想到自焚之类的。

▶ But I can see how that sounds.

但我能理解它的语气。

▶ But in Chinese, it sounds like I think that in English, you play with fire, you might get burned is idiomatic.

但在中文里，“玩火者必自焚”比英文的“玩火自焚”更强烈。

[Back to Top](#)

00:07:50

▶ It almost loses its emotive content.

英文几乎失去了情感色彩。

▶ But in Chinese, it sounds a bit more like self-immolation.

但在中文里，听起来更像自焚。

▶ In fact.

事实上。

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ Exactly.

没错。

▶ Just around this out, my personal favorite of the Chinese to English translation, which sounds terrible to English speakers, how would you translate the term assassin's mace?

说到这个，我个人最喜欢的中译英例子是“杀手锏”，英文听起来很怪。

▶ Assassin's mace.

“杀手锏”。

▶ I don't know.

我不知道。

[Back to Top](#)

00:08:12

▶ What is that?

这是什么？

▶ That's shashoujian.

“杀手锏”。

▶ Shashoujian.

“杀手锏”。

▶ Oh.

哦。

▶ You know it, right?

你知道对吧？

▶ Yes.

是的。

▶ Well, I don't think I hear it in English very often.

但我不常在英语中听到。

▶ But yes, shashoujian.

但中文是“杀手锏”。

00:08:22

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ It's kind of like your secret weapon or the one trick.

像是你的秘密武器或绝招。

▶ Your trump card.

你的王牌。

▶ That's your trump card.

就是王牌。

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ Oh, assassin's mace.

哦，“杀手锏”。

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ I don't hear every often in English.

我不常在英语中听到。

00:08:34

▶ It's teaching things like to call the world's dependence on China for certain advanced technologies, things like solar panels, EVs, because of this China's shashoujian.

比如称世界在某些先进技术上依赖中国，如太阳能板、电动车，这就是中国的“杀手锏”。

▶ Oh, yeah.

哦，是的。

▶ And it's the it's the ace up China sleeve.

这是中国的“王牌”。

▶ Right.

对。

▶ But when it's translated to English, the assassin's mace sounds terrible.

但翻译成英文“assassin's mace”听起来很糟糕。

▶ Also, it costs him as the assassin.

而且把中国比作“刺客”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:08:55

▶ It doesn't sound great.

听起来不太好。

▶ And we should tell him, please stop saying that.

我们应该告诉他们，别这么说了。

▶ It was also quite striking now that I've listened to some of the examples you've curated for me that the modern day Chinese and the political language that the party likes to use is very much language of the people.

听完你整理的例子后，我注意到现代中文和政党喜欢的政治语言非常贴近群众。

▶ You know, Mao is a big supporter of farmers and workers.

比如毛泽东非常支持农民和工人。

[Back to Top](#)

00:09:14

▶ You're meant to say things that are quite catchy.

他们喜欢用朗朗上口的表达。

▶ And you know, even a child can remember these simple phrases.

甚至孩子都能记住这些简单口号。

▶ It's very strong branding that they have.

这是他们很强的品牌塑造。

▶ Yeah, that's right.

是的。

▶ I mean, if I remember right, Mao went through several big drives to try to simplify the language and force an official list of simplified characters, which are still in use today.

我记得毛泽东曾大力推动语言简化，强制推行简体字，至今仍在用。

[Back to Top](#)

00:09:34

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ And of course, part of that drive was for literacy.

当然，部分目的是扫盲。

🎧 But I guess for us, these ambiguities are interesting and maybe a bit of fun for quiz.

但对我们来说，这些模糊性很有趣，甚至像小测验。

🎧 But the ambiguity also creates some real challenges, right?

但模糊性也带来实际挑战，对吧？

🎧 When it comes to how China engages with the world.

在中国与世界互动时。

🎧 And in particular, China's most important relationship with the United States.

尤其是中美这一最重要的关系。

[Back to Top](#)

00:09:56

🎧 And so when I was reporting this story, I was lucky enough to speak with Chaz Freeman, who has navigated this on the front lines at the very highest level.

我在报道时采访了查兹·弗里曼，他曾在一线处理最高层的外交事务。

🎧 Chaz was President Nixon's translator when he traveled to meet Chairman Mao in Beijing in 1972.

查兹是1972年尼克松总统访华会见毛泽东时的翻译。

🎧 Wait, so you spoke to someone who spoke to Chairman Mao or wasn't the same room with him?

等等，你采访了和毛泽东交谈过的人？

[Back to Top](#)

00:10:17

▶ Exactly.

是的。

▶ Justin Trip was a very important trip because essentially set a motion in China's reopening.

尼克松访华非常重要，因为它开启了中国重新开放的进程。

▶ Yeah, that's right.

没错。

▶ It was hugely consequential.

影响深远。

▶ Nixon wanted to capitalize on the distrust between China and its big brother, the Soviet Union.

尼克松想利用中苏之间的不信任。

▶ So he traveled to Beijing.

所以他去了北京。

▶ And Chaz was there to help translate it.

查兹负责翻译。

▶ I know Chaz is not only fluent in Chinese, but also French, Spanish, and Arabic.

查兹不仅精通中文，还会法语、西班牙语和阿拉伯语。

[Back to Top](#)

00:10:40

▶ Did you get a sense from him if Chinese was the hardest for him to pick up?

你觉得中文对他来说最难学吗

🎧 Well, I think Chinese distinguishes itself as being very difficult for non-native speakers.

嗯，我认为中文对非母语者来说非常难学。

🎧 He did tell me though about one of his Chinese teachers when he was learning in Washington, DC, a northern Chinese man who assured him Chinese isn't as hard as it seems.

不过他曾告诉我，他在华盛顿学中文时的一位中国北方老师向他保证，中文并不像看起来那么难。

[Back to Top](#)

00:10:58

🎧 He said probably somebody's told you that Chinese is a very hard language to learn.

他说可能有人告诉过你中文是一门很难学的语言。

🎧 He said, don't believe them.

他说，别信他们。

🎧 Their 800 million has that time.

他们有8亿人都会说中文。

🎧 They're 800 million Chinese.

中国有8亿人。

🎧 And most of them are dumb as door posts and yet they speak Chinese.

而且他们大多数人都很普通，但都会说中文。

🎧 Sure numbers came.

数量摆在那里。

🎧 There's enough of them.

有足够多的人会说。

▶ It can't be that hard.

所以中文不可能那么难。

[Back to Top](#)

00:11:18

▶ That's exactly right.

确实如此。

▶ I find that kind of comforting to think about.

我觉得这种想法挺让人安心的。

▶ Was the Nixon trip his first time in China?

尼克松访华是他第一次来中国吗？

▶ Yeah, it was Chaz's first trip.

是的，那是查兹第一次来中国。

▶ Obviously back then he couldn't go to mainland China to learn Chinese.

显然，那时候他还不能去中国大陆学中文。

▶ So instead he was sent off to Taiwan for language training.

所以他被派去台湾接受语言培训。

▶ So that was his first time to mainland China to Shanghai and Beijing.

那是他第一次到中国大陆的上海和北京。

[Back to Top](#)

00:11:38

▶ Oh wow.

哦，哇。

▶ Learning Chinese in Taiwan's quite a different experience.

在台湾学中文是很不一样的体验。

▶ Like my hometowns are at a cross from Taiwan.

比如我的家乡和台湾隔海相望。

▶ The type of language and lingo they use is slightly different from the northern sort of Chinese ones.

他们用的语言和俚语与中国北方的有些不同。

▶ Did you get a sense from him what it was like dealing with Chinese interpreters in the 70s?

你有没有从他那里了解到70年代与中国译员打交道的感受？

▶ I think learning Chinese in Taiwan does create some complications.

我认为在台湾学中文确实带来了一些复杂问题。

[Back to Top](#)

00:12:01

▶ I mean, even within mainland China there are different dialects, different ways of saying the same thing.

我是说，即使在中国大陆内部也有不同的方言，对同一事物的不同表达方式。

▶ And so you mentioned that he on his first trip to China with President Nixon got into several of these disputes and disagreements with the Chinese interpreters at the time.

所以你提到他第一次随尼克松总统访华时，与当时的中国译员发生了多次争执和分歧。

▶ For example, one of those disagreements, which is quite important, was over how to translate the word deterrence.

例如，其中一个很重要的分歧是关于如何翻译“威慑”这个词。

[Back to Top](#)

00:12:21

▶ The Chinese word for deterrence in Taiwan was hutsu to intimidate and prevent basically or block, which is a very good translation.

台湾对“威慑”的中文翻译是“吓阻”，意思是恐吓和阻止，这个翻译很好。

▶ The word on the mainland was wa shou, which means an active, aggressive approach to the other side.

而大陆的翻译是“威慑”，意思是对对方采取主动、进攻性的态度。

▶ It doesn't imply restraint.

它并不包含克制的意思。

▶ So when we got into talking about deterrence, the Chinese interpreter actually mispronounced wa shou.

所以当我们讨论“威慑”时，那位中国译员实际上把“威慑”读错了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:12:47

▶ She pronounced it wa niah.

她读成了“威摄”。

▶ She misread the second character in the phrase.

她把第二个字读错了。

🎧 I corrected her, but I said, you know, this is really not a good translation of deterrence.

我纠正了她，但我说，你知道，这真的不是“威慑”的好翻译。

🎧 And anyway, we got into quite a disagreement.

总之，我们产生了很大的分歧。

🎧 It took the Chinese Academy of Military Sciences 50 years to come up with a decent translation, which is still not much used.

中国军事科学院花了50年才想出一个像样的翻译，但现在仍然很少用。

[Back to Top](#)

00:13:11

🎧 And that is shudger, which means to intimidate and stop.

那就是“慑止”，意思是恐吓和阻止。

🎧 50 years since he first raised it with the Chinese.

从他第一次向中方提出这个问题已经50年了。

🎧 It's a long time.

时间很长。

🎧 It's still ongoing today, right?

现在还在继续，对吧？

🎧 Yeah, I would say if you told me deterrence today, my initial response would still be wa shou, which he says is sort of active aggression.

是的，我想如果你今天问我“威慑”，我的第一反应仍然是“威慑”，他说这有点主动进攻的意思。

🎧 It also goes to show how important the position of the interpreter is, how much power they have on their hands.

这也说明了译员的职位有多重要，他们手中有多大的权力。

[Back to Top](#)

00:13:40

▶ If just being in the room the way you interpret the word deterrence could have very actively aggressive meanings or quite restrained and saying, you know, we're here to intimidate and stop.

如果在房间里，你对“威慑”一词的翻译可以带有非常主动进攻的含义，也可以相当克制，比如“我们是来恐吓和阻止的”。

▶ That's right.

没错。

▶ I mean, Charles said that it's the translators duty to be a faithful echo of that political master.

我是说，查尔斯说过，译员的职责是忠实传达政治领导人的意思。

▶ But of course, you have to wonder what role intention must play in this.

但你当然会想，意图在这里扮演了什么角色。

[Back to Top](#)

00:14:04

▶ Yeah, makes sense.

是的，有道理。

▶ And, you know, as I mentioned, Nixon's visit really put into motion this idea that China's opening up and one of the most important moments in the China-US relationship took place

a few years later in 1979 when America and China agreed to formally establish diplomatic relations.

而且，正如我提到的，尼克松的访问真正推动了中国开放的想法，中美关系中最重要时刻之一发生在几年后的1979年，当时美国和中国同意正式建立外交关系。

▶ Yeah, that's right.

是的，没错。

[Back to Top](#)

00:14:25

▶ So this is, of course, the Shanghai communique in 1979.

所以这当然是1979年的上海公报。

▶ And one of the biggest sticking points in that negotiation was over the status of Taiwan, which at that time was ruled by the KMT, the Nationalist Party, which had retreated there during the Chinese Civil War.

谈判中最大的症结之一是台湾的地位问题，当时台湾由国民党统治，他们是在中国内战期间撤退到那里的。

▶ The Chinese side wanted America to say that it recognized the PRC's claim over the island, but the American diplomats were very reluctant to do this.

中方希望美国承认中华人民共和国对台湾的主权主张，但美国外交官非常不愿意这样做。

[Back to Top](#)

00:14:49

▶ Was Charles there to witness and sort of help negotiate?

查尔斯在场见证并协助谈判了吗？

🎧 So Charles wasn't at that negotiation, but he told me a little bit about how it went down.

查尔斯没有参加那次谈判，但他告诉我一些谈判的情况。

🎧 Of course, everybody who was familiar with the original text of the Shanghai communique noticed a change in the Chinese word for acknowledge to Chen Ren from Ren Shidong, which was the original phrasing.

当然，所有熟悉上海公报原文的人都注意到中文的“承认”从“认是”改成了“承认”，这是最初的措辞。

[Back to Top](#)

00:15:14

🎧 So I do not know why that happened, but the only explanation that is logical is that this was a deliberate splitting of the difference on a position where there could be no final agreement.

我不知道为什么会这样，但唯一合理的解释是这是在无法达成最终共识的立场上故意采取的折中方案。

🎧 I remember reading the accounts from the Chinese counterparts who were involved in this and how they sort of mold over it for a long time, because like he said, the attitudes from the Americans are quite fuzzy.

我记得读过参与谈判的中方人员的记述，他们如何长时间纠结于此，因为正如他所说，美国的态度相当模糊。

🎧 But ultimately, deputy for a minister at the time, Zhang Wenjin made the call on acknowledge as Chen Ren, because it suits China's stance.

但最终，当时的副部长章文晋决定用“承认”，因为这符合中国的立场。

[Back to Top](#)

00:15:48

▶ Yeah, so what's funny is that not only does the English and Chinese translation of the Shanghai communique use a different word, but also it seems like there might be a different retelling of how this came about.

是的，有趣的是，上海公报的英文和中文翻译不仅用了不同的词，而且似乎对这件事的来龙去脉也有不同的说法。

▶ So you can go online and find a White House memo from a couple of days after the Shanghai communique was signed, in which you see that the National Security Advisor at the time is realizing that the Chinese translation differs.

你可以在网上找到上海公报签署几天后的一份白宫备忘录，里面提到当时的国家安全顾问意识到中文翻译有出入。

▶ And at least in that memo, they claim that they never sought to check the Chinese translation and weren't really sure how it ended up there in the first place.

至少在备忘录中，他们声称从未要求核对中文翻译，也不确定最初是怎么变成这样的。

[Back to Top](#)

00:16:21

▶ Oh, so they're the same as the Chinese snuck it in.

哦，所以他们认为中方偷偷加进去的。

▶ That's the claim.

他们是这么说的。

▶ And then there are some very strict instructions to deny, deny, deny.

然后还有一些非常严格的指示，要求否认、否认、再否认。

▶ Do you have a sense of how unusual this was for an ear like this to happen?

你觉得这种事情有多不寻常？

▶ I mean, the Shanghai communique is probably the most consequential example of this that we could think of, but it doesn't seem like a historical oddity either.

我是说，上海公报可能是我们能想到的最重要的例子，但这似乎也不是历史上的特例。

[Back to Top](#)

00:16:45

▶ It's not an outlier.

这不是个例。

▶ There's a great study by Sabine Mockery, who is at Leiden University in the Netherlands.

荷兰莱顿大学的萨宾·莫克里做过一项很棒的研究。

▶ And she found that in almost half of the translated foreign policy documents that China has released between 2013 and 2019, there were differences between the English and Chinese versions.

她发现，在2013年至2019年中国发布的外交政策文件中，几乎有一半的英文和中文版本存在差异。

▶ She argues that these are differences that would change how we'll read of views China's intentions.

她认为这些差异会改变我们对中国意图的理解。

[Back to Top](#)

00:17:10

▶ I know that sometimes with the translation of the foreign ministry pressers or with some of the live interviews, they would redact some of the things that are said in Chinese and not put it into the English version.

我知道有时候外交部记者会或一些现场采访的翻译中，他们会删掉中文说的一些内容，不放进英文版本。

🎧 Occasionally in my Instagram feed, I get videos put in there and my algorithm from China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

偶尔我的Instagram推送里会出现中国外交部的视频。

🎧 Don't ask why my Instagram algorithm feeds me that.

别问我为什么我的Instagram算法会推送这些。

[Back to Top](#)

00:17:32

🎧 But I've also noticed that the English subtitles they put over the videos of *** speaking, a differ from what he is saying in Chinese.

但我还注意到，他们在***讲话视频上加的英文字幕与他实际说的中文有出入。

🎧 Can you think of any examples of language used by Americans or people in the West being mistranslated or misinterpreted by the Chinese?

你能想到美国人或西方人使用的语言被中方误译或误解的例子吗？

🎧 Well, of course, it goes both ways, right?

当然，这是双向的，对吧？

🎧 We already heard the example from Chaz of Weixia and deterrence and that still exists today.

我们已经听过查兹关于“威慑”的例子，现在仍然存在。

[Back to Top](#)

00:17:56

▶ Another common problematic translation is of competitor.

另一个常见的有问题的翻译是“competitor”（竞争者）。

▶ So President Biden would refer to China as a competitor, rather than the term that he used for Russia, which was opponent.

拜登总统称中国为“competitor”，而对俄罗斯则用“opponent”（对手）。

▶ But can you think about what they might use for competitor?

但你能想到他们可能用什么词翻译“competitor”吗？

▶ What? Jingjing, a Dui Xiaol.

什么？“竞竞对”？

▶ Exactly.

没错。

▶ They sound similar in Chinese almost.

它们在中文里听起来几乎一样。

[Back to Top](#)

00:18:21

▶ But a little bit different, right?

但有点不同，对吧？

▶ Competitor to Jingjing Dui Xiaol.

“competitor”对应“竞竞对”。

▶ The Chinese rendition of that is a bit more zero-summit.

中文翻译更偏向零和思维。

▶ I win you lose.

我赢你输。

🎧 And I think ambiguity is not just a tool used by the Chinese or the Americans.

我认为模糊性不仅仅是中方或美方使用的工具。

🎧 I remember having this conversation with a British friend who half jokingly says, you know, our long standing position on Taiwan has not changed.

我记得和一个英国朋友聊过，他半开玩笑地说，我们对台湾的长期立场没有改变。

[Back to Top](#)

00:18:45

🎧 Then when I pressed and asked, but really, what is the case position?

当我追问，那到底是什么立场？

🎧 He said, like I said, our position has not changed.

他说，就像我说的，我们的立场没有改变。

🎧 It saves one having to go back and actually read the difference between the one China principle, one China policy.

这样就不用回去细究“一个中国原则”和“一个中国政策”的区别了。

🎧 It's very easy for busy diplomats to get confused, I imagine.

我想，忙碌的外交官很容易搞混。

🎧 So if you add all of these things up, the tricky nature of Chinese, the ambiguous way in which things can be interpreted, and how much of this is intentional, how much is lost in translation, you start to see really how much room there is for misunderstanding.

所以如果你把这些都加起来，中文的复杂性、解释事物的模糊性，以及有多少是故意的，有多少是翻译中丢失的，你就会真正看到误解的空间有多大。

[Back to Top](#)

00:19:19

🎧 And that can have very real, real world consequences.

而这可能会产生非常真实的现实后果。

🎧 So we've established that linguistic differences can complicate relations between the great powers, with us to explore the consequences that all this could have in the real world.

所以我们确认了语言差异会使大国关系复杂化，接下来我们要探讨这一切在现实世界中可能产生的后果。

🎧 We're joined by the economist, geopolitics editor, and drum tower OG, David Renny.

我们请来了经济学家、地缘政治编辑和“鼓楼”元老戴维·伦尼。

[Back to Top](#)

00:19:46

🎧 Hello, good to be back.

你好，很高兴回来。

🎧 Long time.

好久不见。

🎧 Yeah.

是的。

🎧 And I like this conversation.

我喜欢这次对话。

🎧 You and I used to have many, many conversations about the pitfalls and the traps and hilarities of English and Chinese when we were on the road.

我们以前在路上经常讨论英语和中文的陷阱、陷阱和趣事。

▶ Yes.

是的。

▶ Now, before we dive in, Corbin and David, have you guys heard of the ultimate translation test for learners of Chinese?

在我们深入之前，科尔宾和戴维，你们听说过中文学习者的终极翻译测试吗？

[Back to Top](#)

00:20:08

▶ I guess we're about to hear it.

我想我们马上就要听到了。

▶ A man hands a packet full of cash to us boss.

一个人递给老板一包现金。

▶ And the boss says, you're not going to say anything.

老板说：“你不会说什么吧。”

▶ And the man says, ah, just you say it.

那人说：“啊，您说。”

▶ And the boss says, ah, you're not going to say anything.

老板说：“啊，你不会说什么吧。”

▶ Yeah, no, like us, yes.

是的，不，像我们这样，是的。

▶ Could I either explain what happened to translate?

我能解释一下发生了什么事吗？

▶ So, you're not going to say anything.

所以，“你不会说什么吧。”

[Back to Top](#)

00:20:30

▶ What does this mean when he sees the packet of cash?

当他看到那包现金时，这是什么意思？

▶ And just you say, you say, it means just a little show of my gratitude.

“您说”意思是“一点小意思，表示我的感谢”。

▶ And I'm going to tell you, you're not going to say anything.

而“你不会说什么吧”意思是“你不会说出去吧”。

▶ You're a very interesting smart person.

你是个非常有趣聪明的人。

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ So, you know, it's all Yishe, but that depending on the context and who saying, it can spawn into, I don't know, 16 different types of meetings.

所以你知道，这都是“意思”，但根据语境和谁说，可以衍生出，我不知道，16种不同的意思。

[Back to Top](#)

00:20:53

▶ That's very good.

这很好。

▶ It's obviously now that we live in the anti-corruption world of ***'s China, that conversation could never take place.

显然，现在我们生活在***反腐的中国，那种对话不可能发生。

▶ David, you spent a long stint in China.

戴维，你在中国待了很长时间。

▶ How has your experience been of navigating Chinese?

你驾驭中文的经历如何？

▶ Well, Jihou has been the witness to a lot of extreme humiliation on my part.

嗯，季厚见证了我很多极其尴尬的时刻。

▶ Because the tones of the things that I have to get wrong as many foreigners speaking Chinese.

因为作为说中文的外国人，我的声调总是搞错。

[Back to Top](#)

00:21:18

▶ And my experience is when you're talking Chinese with people who've met foreigners before, if you've got a tone wrong, they can say, OK, this is an idiot foreigner.

我的经验是，当你和见过外国人的人说中文时，如果你的声调错了，他们会说，好吧，这是个傻老外。

▶ He's got his tone wrong.

他声调错了。

▶ But if you're talking to villagers, they just can't work out what you're doing.

但如果你和村民交谈，他们根本搞不懂你在做什么。

▶ And so, quite a lot of conversations in villages in the countryside.

因此，在农村的村子里有很多这样的对话。

[Back to Top](#)

00:21:32

🎧 I would ask my question in Chinese, Jihou knew what I meant, that the village was looking totally blank.

我会用中文提问，Jihou明白我的意思，但村民们一脸茫然。

🎧 And so, we had this joke that Jihou's job in these cases was to draw when Fanyi-tang draw when.

于是我们开玩笑说，Jihou的工作就是“翻译堂”式的翻译。

🎧 So, to translate my Chinese into Chinese.

也就是说，把我的中文翻译成中文。

🎧 And to then say to my ears, exactly the same thing.

然后对我说完全一样的话。

🎧 And everyone would understand.

这样大家就都明白了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:21:49

🎧 Maybe it's just they're just taking me at face value.

也许他们只是从字面上理解我的话。

🎧 I would say though, sometimes it's cultural, that things you would ask as an English language correspondent, like, how does this make you feel?

不过我觉得，有时候是文化差异，比如作为英语记者，你会问“这让你感觉如何？”

▶ But it doesn't really translate.

但这样的问题很难翻译。

▶ Essentially, you have to give them, like, does it make you feel good or bad?

实际上，你得问得更直白，比如“这让你感觉好还是不好？”

▶ Like, you have to sort of spell it out a bit more.

也就是说，你得解释得更清楚一些。

[Back to Top](#)

00:22:08

▶ And other times, Chinese is just not very straightforward.

还有些时候，中文本身就不太直白。

▶ The slightest difference in tone or in your phrasing could just completely change the direction of where you want it to be.

语气或用词的细微差别都可能完全改变你想表达的方向。

▶ Yeah, actually, I remember when we started doing drum-tire recordings on the side of interviews for the columns, I would be asking people if we could use the audio that we just recorded for our podcast.

是的，我记得我们开始为专栏采访做录音时，我会问人们是否可以用刚才录制的音频做播客。

[Back to Top](#)

00:22:30

▶ And I was saying, Lee Yong, like, use.

我当时说的是“利用”。

▶ And then you eventually said to me, that sounds like exploit, take advantage of.

后来你告诉我，这听起来像“剥削”或“占便宜”。

▶ And so it's much better to say shui Yong, to use as into employ.

所以更好的说法是“使用”或“采用”。

▶ That was a good lesson.

这是个很好的教训。

▶ Western media already has so much bad rap.

西方媒体已经有很多负面形象了。

▶ Yeah, exactly.

没错。

▶ You do to go around spreading or reinforcing some of these stereotypes.

你不能再到处传播或强化这些刻板印象了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:22:51

▶ I'm here to exploit you, yes.

“我来剥削你们了”，确实如此。

▶ But beyond language and cultural differences, how things are translated can have very real world consequences.

但除了语言和文化差异，翻译的方式可能带来非常现实的后果。

▶ You know, earlier when we heard from Chas Freeman, he mentioned the Shanghai Communica as a prime example of strategic ambiguity, a way to reach something without having a final agreement.

早些时候我们听Chas Freeman提到,《上海公报》是战略模糊性的典型例子,即在最终协议的情况下达成某种共识。

[Back to Top](#)

00:23:11

▶ Do you agree with that statement?

你同意这种说法吗?

▶ You know, has the ambiguity in this case created more trouble than it solved?

这种模糊性是否带来了比解决的问题更多的麻烦?

▶ Actually, it's tied into the fact that so much Chinese diplomacy is about power balances and power relationships.

实际上,这与中国的许多外交行为都涉及权力平衡和权力关系有关。

▶ And so I think really what you often see is that the stronger party in order to undo a crisis has to make a concession to the weaker party.

因此,我认为你经常看到的是,强势一方为了化解危机,不得不向弱势一方做出让步。

[Back to Top](#)

00:23:34

▶ But everyone understands that the stronger party is still the stronger party.

但大家都明白,强势一方仍然是强势一方。

▶ And I think actually some of these problems of language going back to the beginnings of China's relationship with America in the 1970s, there actually a reflection of the fact that since then, China has just become stronger and caught up.

我认为，这些语言问题可以追溯到1970年代中美关系的开端，实际上反映了自那时以来中国变得更强大并赶上了美国。

▶ And so the fungees that worked a couple of generations ago no longer quite work in the same way.

因此，几代人前有效的“模糊策略”现在不再适用了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:23:56

▶ Of course.

当然。

▶ And in the case of the Shanghai Communicaay, that was signed at a time where there was a lot of goodwill.

而《上海公报》签署时，双方有很多善意。

▶ And both sides really wanted to reach an agreement.

双方都真心想达成协议。

▶ But if you think about today when trust is increasingly in short supply and tensions are on the rise, we really have to think about how language might play a role in times of crisis.

但如果你想想今天，信任日益稀缺，紧张局势加剧，我们真的需要思考语言在危机时刻可能扮演的角色。

[Back to Top](#)

00:24:16

▶ Over your time reporting on China, do you think there are any kind of good examples that we can flash back to of where language and times of crisis when goodwill is not there?

在你报道中国的经历中，有没有什么好的例子可以回顾，展示在缺乏善意时语言和危机时刻的关系？

▶ How that might play a different role?

它可能如何发挥不同的作用？

▶ Yeah.

是的。

▶ As soon as I heard you were doing this episode, I was immediately reminded about crisis that I covered, oh wow, 24 years ago now, in 2001.

一听说你们要做这期节目，我立刻想起了2001年报道的一场危机，哇，已经是24年前了。

[Back to Top](#)

00:24:36

▶ So some may remember that there was an American spy plane that a Chinese fighter jet collided with this spy plane off the coast of Hainan and Aina, way down south from the South China Sea.

有些人可能还记得，当时一架美国间谍飞机与中国战斗机在海南岛附近相撞，位于南海以南。

▶ The Chinese pilot died because he went into the sea.

中国飞行员坠海身亡。

▶ And the American spy plane had to do an emergency landing because it was very badly damaged and ended up landing at a military air base in Hainan and in China.

美国间谍飞机严重受损，不得不紧急降落在中国海南的一个军事基地。

[Back to Top](#)

00:25:00

▶ And the crew was held as hostages and I was down with lots of other reporters.

机组人员被扣为人质，我和许多其他记者都在现场。

▶ For it was probably two weeks while they negotiated the release and a very brilliant Swedish diplomat friend of mine who I won't name his blushes, but he's one of the best China analysts I know.

谈判释放大约持续了两周，我的一位非常出色的瑞典外交官朋友（为保护他的隐私不提名字）是我认识的最好的中国问题专家之一。

▶ He said, I see the beginning of this, you know, they're going to fix this with a fudge translation.

他说，我看出来了，他们会用模糊翻译来解决这个问题。

[Back to Top](#)

00:25:20

▶ That's how they'll do it.

这就是他们的做法。

▶ Because in particular, the American side was saying it was not their fault that the Chinese pilot had been flying way too close.

因为美国方面特别强调，这不是他们的错，是中国飞行员飞得太近。

▶ The Chinese side obviously said that it was the Americans fault and China wanted an apology for the fact that the American plane landed without permission in a Chinese air base.

中国方面则明确表示这是美国的错，并要求美国就飞机未经许可降落在中国的空军基地道歉。

[Back to Top](#)

00:25:38

▶ And that apology was the core of the problem.

而道歉是问题的核心。

▶ And eventually, America issued a letter saying that it was very sorry about the entering of China's air space and that the landing did not have verbal clearance.

最终，美国发布了一封信，表示对进入中国领空和未经口头许可降落“非常抱歉”。

▶ And they said they were very sorry for the death.

他们还对飞行员的死亡表示“非常抱歉”。

▶ Of the pilot.

飞行员的。

▶ But as you know, Corbin, in English saying, you're very sorry that someone died does not necessarily mean the same as saying that you caused the death.

但你知道，Corbin，在英语中说“对某人的死亡非常抱歉”并不等同于承认是你导致了死亡。

[Back to Top](#)

00:26:02

▶ So that was the fudge.

这就是模糊之处。

▶ Yeah, what are the variations of how you might say sorry or apologize in Chinese?

是的，中文中“抱歉”或“道歉”有哪些不同的表达方式？

▶ I actually did a little piece for the daily paper that I was working for back then in 2000, one about all the various different forms of apology in Chinese and how those would work.

我曾在2000年为我当时工作的日报写过一篇小文章，介绍中文中各种道歉形式及其含义。

▶ Let me set it to you.

我来给你看看。

▶ Okay, so we've got it up here.

好的，我们这里有。

[Back to Top](#)

00:26:23

▶ So at the lower end of this spectrum, we have Bo Yisa, which I might use on a daily basis, if I don't hold the door for someone or something like that, Jihou, what do you kind of make of the ascending order here?

在这个光谱的低端是“不好意思”，我可能会在日常生活中用，比如没为别人扶门之类。Jihou，你觉得这个递进顺序怎么样？

▶ It's interesting.

很有意思。

▶ I don't know what it says about Chinese culture that we have so many different variations and like what your title suggests, sorry is the hardest word.

我不知道这么多不同的表达方式说明了中国文化的什么，就像你的标题说的，“抱歉是最难说出口的词”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:26:46

▶ So in the piece that I wrote back in 2001 without my then brilliant assistant, we thought the difference was if you had the final three in terms of severity.

我在2001年写的那篇文章中（当时没有我那位出色的助手），我们认为最严重的三种道歉的区别在于：

▶ So Yihang would be, I'm sorry that the bicycle you lent me broke.

“遗憾”可能是“很遗憾你借给我的自行车坏了”。

🎧 And then Bao Qian would be sorry I broke your bicycle.

“抱歉”是“抱歉我弄坏了你的自行车”。

🎧 And then Dao Qian is I stone your bicycle.

而“道歉”是“我弄坏了你的自行车，非常抱歉”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:27:05

🎧 I am very sorry.

我非常抱歉。

🎧 Do you think that's reasonable?

你觉得这合理吗？

🎧 Yeah, I would say Yihang is still not as strong.

是的，我觉得“遗憾”仍然不够强烈。

🎧 Like Bao Qian and Dao Qian would be the strongest.

“抱歉”和“道歉”才是最强烈的。

🎧 Like you recognize your mistake.

表示你承认了自己的错误。

🎧 Just to the label of the point, I mean there are seven variations of how to say sorry here, how to apologize.

简单总结一下，这里有七种表达“抱歉”或“道歉”的方式。

🎧 Yes.

是的。

▶ And you know, keep in mind, 2001, this was when often critiques of President Jiang Zemin and the foreign ministry at the time was that they weren't tough enough.

记住，2001年时，人们经常批评江泽民和外交部不够强硬。

[Back to Top](#)

00:27:34

▶ You know, that they weren't certainly weren't as tough as Chairman Mao.

他们当然没有毛主席那么强硬。

▶ And people used to send calcium powder to the foreign ministry to be like, you guys need to be tougher with Americans and with the West.

人们曾给外交部寄钙粉，意思是“你们需要对美国和西方更强硬”。

▶ Wait, why calcium powder?

等等，为什么是钙粉？

▶ Oh, because they lack backbone.

哦，因为他们“缺钙”（没骨气）。

▶ And calcium powder would help.

钙粉会有帮助。

▶ Well, at least Chinese nationalists have a sense of humor.

至少中国民族主义者有幽默感。

[Back to Top](#)

00:27:55

▶ Had you heard of this, David?

David, 你听说过这个吗?

🎧 I have literally had Chinese diplomats tell me that they have to be strong in defending the interests of 1.4 billion Chinese people because they get sent chalk tablets through the post to have all that.

真的有中国外交官告诉我, 他们必须强硬捍卫14亿中国人的利益, 因为他们会收到邮寄的钙片。

🎧 So it's a thing.

所以这是真的。

🎧 But Corbin is interesting to note now we've been through that list of apologies.

但Corbin, 有趣的是, 我们现在已经梳理了这些道歉表达。

[Back to Top](#)

00:28:11

🎧 That the Chinese side back in 2001, they played around with some of this stuff.

2001年中国方面在这些表达上做了文章。

🎧 So there was a moment when Colin Powell then sexually stated expressed sorrow that the Chinese pilots had died.

当时美国国务卿鲍威尔曾表示对中国飞行员的死亡“感到遗憾”。

🎧 And that was translated as lhan, which obviously has more of a sense of kind of regret and guilt.

这被翻译为“遗憾”, 显然带有更多悔意和负罪感。

🎧 And my memory is that the very sorry in the letter from the American ambassador was translated as I think Baochie rather than Daochie.

我记得美国大使信中的“非常抱歉”被翻译为“抱歉”而非“道歉”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:28:36

▶ But I don't hold me to that.

但我不确定。

▶ So I guess where they landed on this list of the scale of apologies that they could've gone for, that's pretty high up.

所以我想他们选择的道歉级别已经相当高了。

▶ It's not Daochie, but it does express some form of guilt or acknowledgement of responsibility, right?

虽然不是“道歉”，但确实表达了某种负罪感或责任承认，对吧？

▶ That's right.

没错。

▶ And I think actually the real lesson to draw from all of that today is if you imagine a similar plane accident crash today, how unbelievably difficult it would be to get it fixed.

我认为，今天从所有这些中得出的真正教训是，如果想象今天发生类似的飞机事故，解决起来会有多难。

[Back to Top](#)

00:29:03

▶ Because the China of the day, it was less nationalist than today.

因为当时的中国民族主义情绪没有今天强烈。

▶ It was much less strong than today.

也比今天弱得多。

▶ China wanted the entry into the WCO.

中国当时想加入世贸组织。

▶ That was their top priority, which is why they eventually did this deal.

这是他们的首要任务，因此最终达成了协议。

▶ And you had a Republican president, George W. Bush, who had just come into office with a Republican Congress, which was willing to cut in some slack.

而当时共和党总统小布什刚上任，共和党控制的国会也愿意让步。

[Back to Top](#)

00:29:22

▶ But I think today's partisan politics and media environment would make it much, much harder on both sides.

但我认为今天的党派政治和媒体环境会让双方都更难妥协。

▶ Yeah, another factor that I think will make this harder to exploit now is, you know, social media was in playing that big of a role back in 2001.

是的，另一个让现在更难解决的因素是，2001年社交媒体还没那么重要。

▶ Now, a lot of people are online, a lot more people understand English and Chinese.

现在很多人上网，更多人懂英语和中文。

[Back to Top](#)

00:29:44

▶ I remember this is back in 2019 when the then Houston Rockets General Manager posted something about Hong Kong that enraged Chinese netizens.

我记得2019年，当时休斯顿火箭队总经理发表了一些关于香港的言论，激怒了中国网民。

▶ NBA had to put out a statement.

NBA不得不发表声明。

▶ And in the English, they said it is regrettable that this happened and this offended our Chinese fans.

英文声明说“对此事感到遗憾，这冒犯了我们的中国球迷”。

▶ And the Chinese, it was much stronger.

而中文声明则强烈得多。

[Back to Top](#)

00:30:06

▶ It was like, we're deeply disappointed in what this manager said.

比如“我们对这位经理的言论深感失望”。

▶ And people were picking up on the intended difference in the Chinese and English copy.

人们注意到了中英文版本的刻意差异。

▶ And we're essentially more angered by the fact that they were trying to do this deviation.

他们试图这样“两面派”的做法反而让人更愤怒。

▶ Right.

没错。

▶ The NBA was trying to have it both ways.

NBA想两头讨好。

▶ They're trying to silo their message.

他们试图分隔信息。

[Back to Top](#)

00:30:25

▶ Right.

是的。

▶ And I think that is becoming more difficult for governments and organizations of all types to try to gatekeep their language or silo the narratives in the Chinese ecosystem and the English one.

我认为，对各国政府和组织来说，试图控制语言或在中英文生态中分隔叙事正变得越来越难。

▶ In particular, technology also seems to be playing a new role in leveling the playing field on translation.

尤其是技术似乎在翻译的公平性上发挥了新作用。

▶ I mean, in 2022, if you recall, after Russia's invasion of Ukraine, there were a group of internet activists who called themselves the Great Translation Movement.

比如2022年俄罗斯入侵乌克兰后，一群自称“大翻译运动”的网络活动家。

[Back to Top](#)

00:30:54

▶ And they said about doing machine translations of ultra-nationalist and pro-Russian rhetoric that was being thrown around inside China.

他们用机器翻译中国国内的极端民族主义和亲俄言论。

▶ In an attempt for outsiders to be able to see what the tone of the conversation that was going on internally was.

试图让外界看到中国内部的舆论风向。

▶ And of course, that really frustrated Chinese state media and the foreign ministry.

这当然让中国官方媒体和外交部非常不满。

▶ Yeah, and how revealing is that?

这多么发人深省啊？

[Back to Top](#)

00:31:15

▶ That the crime was to reveal what was actually being said in Chinese.

“罪行”竟然是揭露中文的真实内容。

▶ I remember an American friend of mine saying that putting something in Chinese in the streets of Beijing was like the first level of encryption.

我记得一位美国朋友说过，在北京街头用中文写东西就像第一层加密。

▶ The foreigners.

外国人看不懂。

▶ And it's that kind of classic thing.

这就是典型的例子。

▶ The foreign sort of business person comes to China, stays in the Hilton Caesar Starbucks and the Mercedes-Jurem and says, don't tell me this place is communist.

这类外国商人来到中国，住在希尔顿凯撒星巴克和奔驰-尤伦酒店里，然后说，别告诉我这里是共产主义国家。

[Back to Top](#)

00:31:36

▶ And then meanwhile, there's red and white banners on the street barriers, right outside the hotel saying, you know, for me hold high the banner of Xi Jinping thought.

而与此同时，酒店外的街道栏杆上挂着红白横幅，上面写着“高举习近平新时代中国特色社会主义思想旗帜”。

▶ But it's all in Chinese.

但这些全是中文。

▶ So have absolutely no idea that there's surrounded by communist party slogans as they head for that latter.

所以他们完全没意识到，自己正被共产党的标语包围着走向酒店。

▶ And so much of covering China as a reporter involves reading between the lines, right?

作为记者报道中国时，很多时候需要解读字里行间的含义，对吧？

[Back to Top](#)

00:31:53

▶ How many times a phrase was mentioned in an annual government report or a phrase, you know, a tifa, a slogan change just ever so slightly?

一个短语在政府年度报告中提了多少次，或者一个提法、口号发生了细微变化？

▶ What could that mean?

这可能意味着什么？

▶ And so language, I think, holds a very important political role within China.

因此我认为，语言在中国政治中扮演着极其重要的角色。

▶ But as you say, David, often it's quite inaccessible for people who are just visiting or people who don't take the time to sort of delve into what the original text might be trying to say.

但正如你所说，大卫，对于短暂来访或不愿花时间钻研原文深意的人来说，这些往往难以理解。

[Back to Top](#)

00:32:18

▶ And actually that's a return to the old school.

这实际上是一种回归传统的方式。

▶ So for you Corbyn, it's very familiar that we're all reading communist party documents and looking for the change in the party line and the doctrines, you say the tifa or I think you have a subscription to Tushua I've seen on your desk, you know what I do.

所以对你来说，科尔宾，我们都在研读共产党文件、寻找路线方针变化的方式很熟悉——比如你说的“提法”，或者我看到你桌上订了《求是》杂志，你知道我的意思。

▶ I do.

是的。

[Back to Top](#)

00:32:32

▶ I do.

确实。

▶ But the journal, when I was a journalist back in the 1990s, we didn't really bother with that stuff.

但上世纪90年代我做记者时，我们根本不在意这些。

▶ You talked to communist party members and they'd be like, ah, I wouldn't bother with that nonsense.

你和共产党员交谈时，他们会说“我才懒得管那些废话”。

▶ We're just busy making money.

我们忙着赚钱呢。

▶ And so it has kind of, we come back to old school reading of party documents in a way that would have been very familiar to the synologists of the 1970s and 1980s.

所以某种程度上，我们又回到了1970-80年代中国问题专家们熟悉的研读党内文件的方式。

[Back to Top](#)

00:32:53

▶ It's kind of come full circle.

这像是一种轮回。

▶ I think one of the ways that communication, especially in the political world, has shifted as well as used to be you receive a printed document, a printed copy.

我认为政治领域的沟通方式也发生了变化——过去你收到的是纸质文件。

▶ And then that's meant to be your reading material.

那就是你的阅读材料。

▶ But the way things have changed, especially, I guess in America now, you have a president who's tweeting about his latest policy.

但如今情况变了，尤其在美国，总统会发推文宣布最新政策。

[Back to Top](#)

00:33:16

▶ That must have an impact on China's delivery as well.

这肯定也影响了中国的信息发布方式。

▶ Yeah, I think it's always, it's extremely difficult for China to do it.

是的，对中国来说这总是极其困难的。

▶ I think one of the fascinating, this goes beyond the question of translation.

我认为一个有趣的现象是——这已超出翻译问题范畴。

▶ But I think it certainly gets to that, the importance of words, that one of the reasons that America and China are a bit stuck, I think, in terms of trying to get out of this trade confrontation, which is, in many ways, hurting both sides, is that Donald Trump's vision is, he has a meeting with Xi Jinping, and the two guys just kind of thrashed out and something brilliant and beautiful will emerge.

但确实涉及用词的重要性：中美在试图摆脱这场对双方都有害的贸易对抗时陷入僵局，部分原因在于特朗普的设想是与习近平会面后，两人激烈讨论就能产生绝妙成果。

[Back to Top](#)

00:33:47

▶ But of course, for the Chinese side, Xi Jinping does not go into any high level meeting unless every last comma and syllable has been agreed in advance.

但中方当然不会这样——习近平绝不会参加任何未事先逐字敲定的高级别会议。

▶ And that's not how President Trump rolls.

这不是特朗普总统的行事风格。

▶ And I think that contrasts in sort of freedom of language versus the absolute importance of agreeing every last word in advance is one of the symptoms of the confrontation moment.

我认为这种语言自由度与必须事先逐字协商之间的反差，正是当前对抗状态的症状之一。

[Back to Top](#)

00:34:08

▶ That's why they're stuck.

所以他们陷入僵局。

🎧 So David and Corbin, usually at this point, we circle back to the question at the top.

大卫、科尔宾，通常这时我们会回到最初的问题。

🎧 But I'd like to think we've covered what makes Chinese so hard to navigate.

但我想我们已经讨论了中文为何如此难掌握。

🎧 I'm curious, though, to finish, are these linguistic word games useful?

不过最后我好奇，这些语言游戏有用吗？

🎧 Or are they actually the sign of a really tough relationship ahead?

还是说它们预示着未来关系的艰难？

[Back to Top](#)

00:34:33

🎧 Yeah, I think that what we've seen is that in the past, differences in language could be used to a lied, real structural problems in the relationship, fundamental disagreements.

是的，我认为过去语言差异曾被用来掩盖关系中真正的结构性问题和根本分歧。

🎧 And I think interlocutors, both on particularly the American side and the Chinese side, often come back to this crutch of, well, we just misunderstand each other.

美中双方的对话者常常依赖这个借口——“我们只是误解了彼此”。

🎧 And actually, what we really need is more understanding.

说“我们真正需要的是更多理解”。

[Back to Top](#)

00:34:56

▶ I think that that's a noble sentiment.

这种观点很高尚。

▶ But also, we can't get too bogged down in this.

但我们也不能过于纠结于此。

▶ I think that there are also very fundamental disagreements in the relationship.

我认为双方存在非常根本的分歧。

▶ And splitting hairs over words, I do think actually is an indication that understanding is kind of the least about problems here.

在措辞上斤斤计较，其实说明理解恰恰是最不重要的。

▶ Corbin, I agree with you, but I think it's also often a weapon.

科尔宾，我同意你，但我觉得这也常被当作武器。

[Back to Top](#)

00:35:15

▶ I mean, not to sound like the kind of the old foreign correspondents, but you know, I've worked in lots, lots of countries and done interviews in French and Spanish and Chinese.

不是要摆老记者架子，但我在许多国家用法语、西班牙语和中文做过采访。

▶ China is unique in terms of these constant discussions about whether the foreigner has misunderstood China, whether foreigners can ever understand China.

中国独特之处在于总在讨论外国人是否误解了中国、外国人能否理解中国。

▶ Is it possible for a foreigner ever to understand?

外国人有可能理解吗？

[Back to Top](#)

00:35:34

▶ It's a power play.

这是一种权力游戏。

▶ It suits China to say we are impossible to understand.

中国乐于宣称“我们是不可能被理解的”。

▶ And if you disagree with me, it's because you failed to understand that I'm right and you're wrong.

如果你不同意我，那是因为你没理解“我才是对的，你是错的”。

▶ But it's just a try-on.

但这只是种试探。

▶ And it goes back a very long way.

其历史非常悠久。

▶ I mean, I was trying to remember the exact historical story.

我在回忆具体的历史事件。

▶ But you know, if you go back several centuries, the first encounter between foreigners and China, it was actually illegal for foreigners to learn Mandarin.

几个世纪前外国人与中国初次接触时，外国人学汉语是非法的。

[Back to Top](#)

00:35:56

▶ Because it was seen as this kind of power thing that as long as foreigners couldn't understand it, they would be reliant on their Chinese translators.

因为这被视为一种权力手段——只要外国人不懂中文，就必须依赖中国译员。

🎧 And I think it was a British diplomatic envoy and their interpreter steps forward and starts speaking to a senior Mandarin whose response is what's treated towards this barbarian Mandarin?

记得一个英国外交使团的译员上前与清朝高官交谈，对方呵斥“何物等夷，敢与天朝言语？”

🎧 So that's the beginning of that meeting.

这就是那次会面的开端。

[Back to Top](#)

00:36:15

🎧 I basically agree.

我基本同意。

🎧 I think that the idea that there are misunderstandings, though there are, that that is the cause of coupling the relationship.

虽然存在误解，但认为这是关系恶化的主因——

🎧 I think that's just an easy answer.

这只是个简单的答案。

🎧 In reality, I think that both sides understand each other well enough to know that there are really fundamental disagreements about their values and how they view the world.

实际上双方都清楚彼此在价值观和世界观上存在根本分歧。

[Back to Top](#)

00:36:34

🎧 Well, this conversation has been Genio Yis.

这次对话精彩绝伦。

▶ Thank you, Corbin and David for joining us on Drum Tower today.

谢谢科尔宾和大卫今天做客《鼓楼》。

▶ We hope to have you back very soon.

期待很快再邀请你们。

▶ Thank you.

谢谢。

▶ Thank you.

谢谢。

▶ Thank you for listening to Drum Tower.

感谢收听《鼓楼》。

▶ And special thanks to Alan, who suggested we explore the topic of translation and planted the seed for this very episode.

特别感谢艾伦建议我们探讨翻译话题，催生了本期节目。

▶ We love hearing from listeners and reading your emails.

我们珍视听众的来信反馈。

[Back to Top](#)

00:37:00

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 Our Science and Tech podcast, Babbage, recently featured two episodes about the Vera Rubin Observatory and how it will transform astronomy.

我们的科技播客《巴贝奇》最近有两期关于薇拉·鲁宾天文台将如何变革天文学的内容。

[Back to Top](#)

00:37:25

 It's really worth listening to.

非常值得一听。

 Lucy Roar and myself produced this episode.

本期节目由露西·罗尔和我制作。

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[Back to Top](#)

